

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 9 3

♥ K 7 6 4

♦ A

♣ J 10 3

♠ K 7 6 2

♥ 5

♦ K J 8 7 4 3

♣ 7 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 5

♥ Q 10 9 8 2

♦ 9 2

♣ 9 8 6 5 4

♠ A 8 4

♥ A J 3

♦ Q 10 6 5

♣ A K Q

West	North	East	South
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♦
Pass	4♦	Pass	5♦
All Pass			

5♦ by South

This looks so easy let's check it by trying a winner count as well. Five ♦s (after ♦A is gone), the ♠ A K, the ♥A and the ♣ A K Q. Yes that adds up to 11 winners.

Is there ANY danger here at all?

Whenever a hand looks easy you should ask yourself what could go wrong. And here the only thing that could go wrong is if one of your ♠ winners gets ruffed. So how can you prevent that possibility?

If East has a singleton ♠, and West has the ♦A you might go down if you win the first trick in your hand. West will take his ♦A and play the ♠J. If you go up with dummy's ♠K East will ruff and you will still have a ♠ loser.

The simple solution is to win the first trick with dummy's ♠K. Now when West wins the ♦A and leads another ♠ it's a different situation. East may well ruff, but if he does you will just play a low card - East will have ruffed your ♠ **LOSER**.

You are a little unlucky that East has a singleton ♠.

But you are very lucky that you took the time to read this hand so you know how to play safely!

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 3♦. Partner now bids 4♦.

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Partner wouldn't bypass 3NT unless he was pretty distributional. His bid is invitational and you have excellent ♦ help so you try 5♦.

South plays 5♦. West leads the ♠Q.

You may be wishing partner had said 3NT. But at 3NT West might have led a ♥, then you'd be wishing you were in 5♦.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 7
♥ K 10 9 2
♦ 7 6
♣ K Q J 8 2

♠ K 8 3 2

♥ 7 6 3

♦ A J 10 4

♣ A 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 9 5 4
♥ J 8
♦ 9 5 3
♣ 10 9 6 5

♠ A J 6

♥ A Q 5 4

♦ K Q 8 2

♣ 7 3

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			

You have 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit. To find a possible 4-4 fit you bid 2♣, the Stayman convention. Partner bids 2♥.

You have 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit. To find a possible 4-4 fit you bid 2♣, the Stayman convention. Partner bids 2♥.

You were hoping for a ♠ response, but so be it. You now bid 3NT, knowing partner will correct to 4♠ if he was 4-4 in the Majors, or pass if he doesn't have 4 ♠s. He passes.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT.

West leads the ♣K, East follows with the ♣10. Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 8

It makes no difference whether you hold up or not, (unless their ♣s are 7-2), so go ahead and take the first trick.

Either the ♥Q or the ♠J **MIGHT** become your ninth trick.

If you try either finesse and it wins you will make your contract. If you try either finesse and it loses you will be set immediately with ♣s. Each finesse is a 50% shot.

Is there anything you can do to improve your chances?

Of course - otherwise the question wouldn't have been asked! You can combine two chances. Obviously you cannot take both finesses, but you can try to drop the ♠Q in two pulls, and if she doesn't drop you still have the ♥ finesse to fall back on. So win the ♣A, play 4 ♦ winners and the ♠ A K, then see whether you have to try the ♥ finesse.

Aha - the ♠Q dropped so you take your 9 tricks.

But if she hadn't, you'd still have a 50% chance in ♥s.